

Transition from Harpsichord to Pianoforte – the important rôle of women

Preliminary

So much research has been devoted to the early pianoforte in recent years, and so many new citations of these instruments have been discovered, that we are now in danger of over-estimating the importance of the pianoforte in the first half of the eighteenth century. Let there be no mistake, prior to 1765 a pianoforte was something rare – an instrument that might be found only in the homes of princes, aristocrats, and art patrons of extraordinary means. The great majority of musicians would be entirely unfamiliar with them.

The reasons for this are not hard to find. First, pianofortes were expensive. The instrument invented by Cristofori, and used subsequently as the pattern for other early pianos, was complex and less easy to manufacture than an ordinary harpsichord. For this reason, and also because there was a premium to be paid for novelty and prestige, makers could demand high prices – and did. As a rule newly manufactured pianofortes cost twice as much as an equivalent harpsichord, which was in itself a costly item. For example, in 1761 J. H. Silbermann of Strasbourg demanded 1500 livres for his ‘piano et forte clavecin’. Second, the tone of the early pianoforte was softer than a plucked instrument, and had less definition, and this sound was not easily accepted by ears that were accustomed to the neat articulation and carrying tone produced by the plucking action of a traditional harpsichord. Thirdly, the Cristofori-style pianoforte was not easy to maintain and regulate. To make any corrections if the tone became uneven, it was necessary to take the hammers and keys out of the instrument, and then make skillful adjustments with a special tool.¹ A princely patron would find this no problem since he could employ people to attend to such matters, or he might demand that the maker himself should see to it, but for ordinary musicians this sort of chore would not be welcome or acceptable. So these three powerful disincentives would be quite enough in themselves to dampen most people’s enthusiasm. But we should also recognize that prior to 1765 there was very little music to be had or heard that made a distinctively different appeal when played on a hammer-action instrument.

Around 1765 this situation was rapidly overturned by the advent of a new type of pianoforte. The square piano (as we now call it) appeared in several designs within the space of a few years, originating in several parts of Germany and in London. Historically the most important manifestation was the so-called ‘English Piano-forte’ invented by John Zumpe, a native of Fürth bei Nürnberg who had settled in London. Zumpe’s invention was of immense importance in raising appreciation of the pianoforte. Not the least important aspect of its reception was its popularity with women. About eighty percent of players were female, and since they constitute overwhelmingly the greater part of the active musical population we would do well always to consider the progress of the pianoforte, and particularly its rapid proliferation after 1765, from the female point of view.

Undeniably there was a tremendous explosion of interest. For example in England in 1760 there were no more than five or six pianofortes (probably even fewer since I may have counted some twice), yet by 1770 the pianoforte in its new guise, as a small rectangular instrument, was widely known and very frequently seen in the homes of the most important musical trend-setters. Already three workshops – those of John Zumpe, John Pohlman, and

¹ Many people find this hard to believe. But I can assure them that if you take out the keys of a Cristofori type

Adam Beyer – were specialising in the manufacture of square pianos to the exclusion of any other instrument, sometimes even subcontracting work to secondary workshops – and yet unable to meet the demand from would-be pianoforte players.² On this basis my calculation is that by December 1770 there were probably a hundred pianofortes in London (compared with a maximum of six a decade earlier). Export was already a lucrative aspect of the trade – the principal market being France, but other instruments going to places as distant as America and St Petersburg – and within seven or eight years annual production was running at about 200 units, with rapid expansion still taking place as craftsmen from other nations studied with Zumpe and probably with other London makers, and then went off to establish their own workshops in Spain, France, Belgium, Netherlands, and northern Germany.

Alongside this burgeoning trade harpsichords were still being manufactured, and eagerly purchased. Accurate production figures can be readily ascertained with regard to the Shudi & Broadwood workshop, because their sales ledgers have survived, detailing the day-to-day transactions throughout most of the 1770s. These reveal that London's second largest manufacturer was selling about twenty new harpsichords each year. Jacob Kirckman's workshop, always able to command the premier position, was probably selling two or three times as many, judging by the numbers in circulation. Add to this the output from minor workshops and one arrives at what I believe to be a cautious estimate of 120 new or reconditioned harpsichords sold each year in the English capital, at an average price of £40 to £50. Alongside this we should place square piano manufacture at about two hundred per year before 1780, selling at an average £20 each. To get some idea of the value of this trade we could make a comparison with the pay received by the men who made the instruments. At this time a skilled craftsman, for example a joiner, might earn two shillings a day – about £35 per annum (if he stayed in good health). A man with specialized skills in the harpsichord or piano trade might earn as much again, up to £1 per week. His total annual pay was equal to one harpsichord or two square pianos. So, in a period of rising prosperity, keyboard instrument manufacture was a lucrative trade, with business booming as never before. Thus the total value of harpsichord sales in 1780 can be computed at about £4500 per annum, and pianos at £4000.

What this means culturally is that during the 1770s and early 1780s harpsichords and pianofortes enjoyed equal popularity. Remembering that there existed already a large pool of harpsichords in use (and many spinets too), and that current manufacture was increasing this resource every month, it is not difficult to postulate that in the late 1770s plucked instruments were more frequently heard than pianofortes, and that parity was attained only about 1785. The vast majority of pianos at that time were of the 'English' type. Thereafter, of course, the meteoric rise of the square piano exceeded all expectations; harpsichord sales slumped; and soon even the finest Flemish harpsichord, revamped by the best Parisian craftsmen, could not be sold for a fraction of its former value.

Musicologists have explained these phenomena in terms of shifting artistic requirements – the change from formal baroque musical language to the expressive freedoms of homophonic early classical style. They cite the need for more immediate, expressive control over dynamics to meet the concomitant demand for a more emotive performance. Some go so far as to relate this change to the work of great philosophers of the so-called 'Enlightenment', and a consequent rise in individualism. But an equally valid and potentially more useful approach might be to consider this transition not by studying the music but the people who played it. Rather than studying black dots on white paper one could consider the social context and significance that music-making acquired. In adopting such an

² To this short list of three makers a fourth can be confirmed by the recent discovery of an example by Frederick Beck, clearly dated 1769, in the Inverclyde Museum, Scotland.

approach the first necessity is to recognize the overwhelming numerical preponderance of women and their key role both as consumers of musical goods and services, and as transmitters within society of cultural developments and values. Any study that fails to recognize this is divorced from reality.

Numerical Evaluations

I have already suggested that something like eighty percent of early pianists were female. Clearly we need some evidence to substantiate this. It might be supposed that we could simply ascertain who owned the newly-made pianofortes, and sort them by gender. In this respect the survival of the Broadwood Books, which include the sales ledgers for the Shudi & Broadwood workshop, might be a promising source. This firm began to manufacture and sell pianos in 1780 and in folio number b107 held by the Bodleian Library, Oxford, we can read the name of each client, the price paid, and sometimes additional information about the instrument.³ Occasionally the ledger even records where the client lived and how the instrument was transported there. Yet as regards the gender distribution of players we learn less than we might have expected. The chief problem is that very many of the instruments were not purchased directly by the end user. Very few women had real financial independence, so it was often husbands who bought for their wives, brothers purchased for their sisters, and fathers for their aspiring daughters. The true identity of the musician is hidden.

There is an amusing illustration of this in Jane Austen's novel *Emma*, where the impoverished Jane Fairfax – who is said to be a fine pianist – loses her place in a wealthy household because the owners are going abroad. So, for the foreseeable future Jane has to live with a maiden aunt, of limited means, in a house where there is no instrument to practice on. Then, to everyone's astonishment, Jane receives the gift of a Broadwood square piano, with pedal, sent direct from London by an anonymous well-wisher. Later, at a dinner party this fascinating news is discussed by all the neighbours, each of the characters speculating on who the mystery benefactor might be. The reader, of course, is expected to make guesses too – almost as if one were reading a 'whodunit' by Agatha Christie. Many chapters later the benefactor is revealed. He turns out to be the wealthy and handsome Frank Churchill, who was at the dinner party but avoided revealing his part in the business because he was even then secretly engaged to marry Jane Fairfax, and wished to keep this secret. Much hangs on this episode in the plot development, and it is interesting to see that Austen as a writer of unquestioned *verité* should depict the purchase of a square piano as an affectionate and thoughtful gesture by Jane Fairfax's future husband.

Very rarely can the delivery of a square piano have been quite such a surprise, or charged with so much meaning, but there can be no doubting that many men paid for such an instrument as a gift, or that women bought by proxy, and this leaves us some difficulty in assessing how many females became the owners of square pianos from Broadwood. Another problem that one encounters with researching the Broadwood Books is signaled by the fact that certain names appear with some frequency. These are often well-known music teachers of the day such as Alexander Reinagle, Felice Giardini, George Dietz and even Muzio Clementi. They were evidently authorized or commissioned by pupils to choose a piano on their behalf. Sometimes, though infrequently, a pupil is indirectly cited; for example, on 14 October 1783 Charles Burney ordered a square piano 'for Lady Cooper'. But generally speaking we do not know the names of the pupils or friends for whom these men ordered the pianos. Sometimes, however, a woman who played the piano (and would be the end user)

³ Bodleian Library, *Broadwood Journals*, Oxford, MSS Eng Misc. b107

did come to Broadwood's shop to select an instrument. A particularly fruitful period for this occurred in November and December 1784 when I find six women visited Broadwood and choose personally – Mrs Baillie, Mrs Bagot, Mrs Henworthy, Mrs Bracebridge, Miss Stewart, and Lady Findlater. In the same period seven men ordered pianos individually, and in addition two were bought by Corri & Sutherland, three by Neil Stewart (both being dealers from Edinburgh), and one by Leotard Cazenova (a frequent client who exported I think to France). So, of the total of twenty pianos sold in the two months only 6 can be seen to be chosen by and for women – apparently thirty per cent. Even if we exclude the dealers it appears that men outnumber women as buyers of pianos, in the ratio of 6:7. My conclusion is that we are compelled to recognise that few women enjoyed economic independence or had sufficient freedom of action and self-confidence to take the initiative themselves. So, in the end, the Broadwood Books turn out to be less useful than expected.

Another way that I considered we might arrive at an estimate of female statistical dominance in this area is by turning to contemporary records of social activity. This can be very time consuming if one were to rely on sparse references in letters and journals, but a good source that is more readily accessed could be a study of the previously noticed novels of Jane Austen – not a truly scientific test perhaps since we are here dealing with fiction, but Austen's writing is regularly examined and cited by social historians. This is because her meticulous and accurate description of people and their circumstances is acknowledged to give a true and credible picture of social conditions among the middle classes to which she belonged. For example, when she reports in *Sense and Sensibility* that the recently widowed Mrs Dashwood has been left with only £500 per year, and that by frugal living she can keep only one maid and a faithful manservant on that income, it rings true for her readers. They knew very well what was credible regarding life styles and incomes.⁴ Details like this occur with great frequency, and Jane Austen gets it right chiefly because she confines her narrative to the social and domestic situations that she knows and understands. So I find it of interest that in her three most widely read novels, *Pride and Prejudice*, *Sense and Sensibility*, and *Emma*, all written between 1795 and 1814, I can count eight female characters who are either described playing the pianoforte, or it is clearly implied that they do. By contrast only one male is said to play (though he says he does not play well, and therefore never sits down to the instrument). So, if Austen is as accurate in this as in her other social reportage she presents a world in which 8 out of 9 (eighty-nine percent) of piano playing was undertaken by women or girls. Jane Austen was born in 1775 and learnt to play herself around 1786, though she did not achieve great proficiency. So it may also be of some interest that in each of these novels the central characters and principal pianists – Elizabeth Bennet, Emma Woodhouse, Jane Fairfax, and Marianne Dashwood – all win the hearts of the most wealthy and handsome men, and at the end of the book each of these musical women marries her man. This leaves only Georgiana Darcy, in *Pride & Prejudice* unwed among the 'fine players of the pianoforte'. But she is only eighteen when the narrative closes, and she does have the consolation of a new and close friendship with sister-in-law Elizabeth Bennet, both women modestly deferring to the other at the keyboard. Notably too, there is implied virtue in pianistic excellence. Mr. Knightley, who eventually marries Emma in the novel of that time, praises Jane Fairfax's playing, and gently criticises his future bride because she will not practice enough to attain the same standard. In *Pride and Prejudice* Elizabeth Bennet chides the taciturn Mr. Darcy when he makes excuses for his lack of social graces. He responds to her criticism by saying: "I certainly do not have that talent which some possess of conversing easily with strangers", but she will not allow this as a valid excuse. He should

⁴ Edward Copeland, *Jane Austen and the Consumer Revolution*, in: *The Jane Austen Handbook*, London 1986, p. 82.

make more effort to overcome his lack of skill. She says: “My fingers do not move over this instrument in the masterly manner which I see so many women’s do. They have not the same rapidity, and do not produce the same expression. But I have always supposed that to be my own fault – because I would not take enough trouble in practicing”. Darcy understands and accepts her rebuke for not taking the trouble to improve himself socially.

For all Jane Austen’s veracity in matters of social manners it is obviously unsatisfactory to take this evaluation of female dominance in music making at face value, unless we can find some corroboration elsewhere. Fortunately, a very informative source has come to light, providing the possibility of making an accurate assessment of female and male participation in this recreation, and very happily its origins are in exactly the geographic and social context depicted by Jane Austen. This new source is the account book kept by Thomas Green⁵, a church organist and music teacher, who lived in Hertford, about 20 miles north of London. Green was often called in by local gentry to tune their keyboard instruments, and being a very methodical person, he kept accurate records of all his activities for more than forty years, noting the name of each client and keeping a careful tally of how much they paid for each visit. Beginning in January 1742, when he tuned Miss Cholmley’s spinet, and thereafter tuning an average of about twenty instruments each year, he has left for posterity an invaluable insight into music making in this locality, up to the summer of 1786. The first mention of a pianoforte occurs in 1770, the owner being Lady Monson of Broxbourne, who also owned a Kirckman harpsichord made in 1764. Green often noted the inscription above the keys of a harpsichord or spinet, and sometimes gives additional details: so for example we know that Mrs Dayley’s harpsichord at Ware Park was made by Burkat Shudi and had two unisons, octave, and lute, but no pedal. Yet, of the forty pianos he tuned Green gives no details whatsoever. They are simply noted as a ‘Forte piano’ or ‘Piano forte’, seemingly using these names interchangeably and indiscriminately. Nevertheless, we have every reason to suppose that these were English square pianos, recently made in London. From Green’s records I have extracted those visits that specifically mention a pianoforte and the name of the person who owned it. (See Table 1.)

This list can be continued to June 21, 1786, in the same fashion. Generally it appears that, in contrast to Broadwood’s sales ledger, Thomas Green’s account book gives a clear picture of who actually plays the instrument. Going through this list to identify individual clients – that is, eliminating repeat appearances, and then making separate tallies by gender – I compiled the list below.

On the face of it there are 35 female and 11 male clients who asked Green to attend to their pianos. But to produce this list a certain amount of intelligent reading was needed

⁵ Gillian Sheldrick (Ed.), *The Accounts of Thomas Green, 17452-1790*, Hertford 1992.

and there are still a few doubtful points. In column 1 there are two Mrs Garniers; this is because it appears that there really were two different people, probably related, very plausibly as mother and daughter-in-law. The first lady lived at Fanham's Hall, the other at Broad Oak End. A similar situation exists regarding Miss Turvin: one lived at Hoddesdon, the other at 'Tarnels', near Gilston. Since the second address occurs in both 1778 and 1781, and the first address occurs in early 1781 the most likely interpretation is that here also there are two individuals named as Miss Turvin. Thus, taking the above lists at face value we have 35 females within a total of 46 piano players; hence females represent $35/46 \times 100 = 76\%$.

1770	27 June	Lady Monson	Forte-piano	10/6
	17 Aug	Mrs Garnier	Forte-piano	5/-
	7 Nov	Lady Caroline Seymour	Hcd & F-piano	10/6
1771	15 March	10/6	F-piano	10/6
	13 Aug	Miss Baggs	Piano-forte	Not paid
1773	21 June	Miss Seymour	Hcd & F-piano	10/6
	18 Oct	Miss Seymour	Hcd & P-forte	10/6
	1 Dec	Captain Gordon	Piano-forte	10/6
1774	8 July	Major Lloyd's lady	Piano-forte	10/6
1775	4 Jan	Miss Miller	Piano-forte & Hcd	10/6
	20 June	Miss Amyand	Hcd & F-piano	£1/1/-
	21 Sept	Miss Amyand	Hcd & F-piano	10/6
	23 Nov	Miss Lutchings	Forte-piano	5/-
	28 Nov	Lord Melborne	Forte-piano	5/-
1776	6 Sept	Lady Melborne	Hcd & P-forte	£1/1/-
	3 Oct	Mrs Harvey	Piano-forte	10/6
1777	1 Feb	Mr Wood	Forte-piano	10/6
	1 Apr	Mrs Harvey	Piano-forte	10/6
	28 Jul	Mr Hale	Piano-forte	10/6
	18 Aug	Mr Buttery	Piano-forte	10/6
	6 Sept	Mr Wood	Piano-forte	10/6
	26 Sept	Mr Clitherow	Hcd & P-forte	15/6
	15 Nov	Mrs Harvey	Piano-forte	10/6
1778	18 Feb	Miss Musgrave	Forte-piano	2/6
	11 June	Mrs Amyand	Hcd & F-piano	15/6
	10 Aug	Miss Turvin	Piano-forte	10/6
	17 Aug	Mr Wood	Piano-forte	10/6
1779	10 May	Miss Van	Forte-piano	5/-
	3 Jun	Miss Stevenson	Piano-forte	10/6
	15 Jun	Lady Effingham	Forte-piano	5/-
	31 Jul	Mrs Wood	Forte-piano	10/6
	20 Nov	Lady Maria Carlton	Piano-forte	5/-
	15 Dec	Mrs Clitherow	Hcd & P-forte	15/6

Table 1 Thomas Green's Pianoforte Tunings, 1770-79

Female clients (pianoforte)		Male clients
Miss Altham	'Major Lloyd's lady'	Mr. Blackmore
Mrs. Amyand	Mrs. Lutchings	Mr. Buttall

Miss Biggs	Lady Melborne	Mr. Buttery
Miss Bevern	Miss Miller	Mr. Clitherow
Miss Braithwaite	Lady Monson	Capt. Gordon
Lady M. Carlton	Miss Musgrave	Mr. Hale
Mrs. Clitherow	Lady Paget	Mr. Ibbot
Miss Cocks	Mrs. Piers	Mr. Leeming
Mrs. Dardis	Mrs. Powers	Lord Melborne
Miss Emmet	Mrs. Roberts	Mr. Musgrave
Miss Farren	Lady Seymour	Mr. Wood
Mrs. Farrendon	Miss Seymour	
Mrs. Garnier [1]	Miss Stevenson	
Mrs. Garnier [2]	Miss Turvin [1]	
Mrs. Hankin	Miss Turvin [2]	
Mrs. Hervey	Miss Van	
Lady Hume	Mrs. Wood	
Mrs. Hutchinson		
Total: 35		Total: 11

Table 2 Green's Pianoforte Clients, sorted by gender

However, there is good reason to think that this result still under-estimates female statistical dominance. Notice that in my analysis I have counted both Mr. Musgrave and Miss Musgrave – yet I suspect that in reality only Miss Musgrave was an active musician. There is evidence to support this because this lady had tuition from Thomas Green during 1775. So it could easily be that only she was active as a keyboard player and that her brother or father merely contracted with Mr. Green on her behalf for a tuning in 1780. Whether this is the correct interpretation we cannot be absolutely certain, but it is worth observing that three other apparent duplications of this kind occur: Mr. and Mrs. Wood at Thunbridge Bury both pay Green (on different occasions) as do Lord and Lady Melborne, likewise Mr. and Mrs. Clitherow. But there is simply no way to be sure of their status. Are we right to count them both as players in each case? Notice also how in July 1774 Green tunes for ‘Major Lloyd’s lady’. This suggests that Green did not know the name of the female musician. Clearly, Major Lloyd called for Green’s services, and paid, but the player was a lady whose name Green did not even know, and who was possibly not even present when he arrived to tune the piano – another clear instance of goods or services for females being ordered by male proxy.⁶ So a bare analysis, simply accepting each name without question, might not truly reflect the gender bias among keyboard players. If we were to translate the known duplications in the Clitherow, Wood, Melborne and Musgrave houses as being in each case for a female pianist (to take the most extreme interpretation) we would be reduced to only seven male piano players and the computation of female bias rises: $35/42 \times 100 = 83\%$. On balance therefore, taking the mean (average) figure between our computed 76 or 83%, I conclude that about 80 per cent of piano players must have been female. By any reckoning there is a huge gender imbalance, and this must be a factor that we should consider when thinking about the rising popularity of the pianoforte during the period 1770 to 1786. (I note also that in those households where a daughter was striving to acquire musical

⁶ Another possible interpretation is that the ‘Lady’ and Major Lloyd were a co-habiting couple, and that Green knew this, but declined to acknowledge it.

accomplishments, with parental support but neither parent played, the identity of such a player would never be shown in Green's accounts, since minors would never pay for the tuning. For this reason I suspect that there may be a hidden clientele, so to speak, who are simply not reported. Hence, 80% may still be a substantial under estimate, and the true figure might be quite close to the 89% computed from Jane Austen's novels).

Attractions of the new Pianoforte

When the ascent of the pianoforte began, around 1766, the musical environment was dominated by the harpsichord, both in public and domestic situations. The first generation of 'pianists' (if we may call them so) was then wholly accustomed to the tone and diction of the harpsichord: its special character pervaded the whole musical environment, and everyone's expectations of keyboard music were entirely conformed to this medium. What, then, made such an immediate appeal when Zumpe's pianofortes appeared?

- First, and most obviously, people liked the novel tone of this instrument. Let us never forget that the most important thing about any musical instrument is the sound it makes. The tone of the early English square piano is described in contemporary writing as being 'sweet', or 'charming'. For those connoisseurs who had heard earlier pianos of the Cristofori type this was something new and quite different from their previous experience. It had a lively diction and an especially plummy, singing treble where, by contrast, so many early grand pianos are disappointing. This was partly achieved by the geometry of Zumpe's soundboard, but more importantly through his innovative stringing. The sounding length of the strings and the thickness of wire used resulted in a drawing tension of about ten kilograms force per string – almost double the Cristofori scheme. And this was made to sound all the more lively by his use of small wooden-headed hammers that were covered only with a thin layer of bookbinder's leather – goat or sheepskin.⁷ It was novel, charming, and utterly characteristic.
- Second, there were stops to change the tone. Lifting the dampers off the strings, so that the sound continued and resonated like a dulcimer was particularly well liked. Combining this with the buff stop (as we now call it) transformed the tone again so that it resembled a gut-strung harp. To produce a drier pizzicato-like tone the dampers remained 'on' when the buff was engaged: sometimes they called this registration 'lute'. These effects were not available on earlier Italian-style pianos or on any harpsichord. Registration changes employing these hand stops were especially useful for imparting a distinctive voice to each section of music, like the effect created in a minuet and trio, where the middle section (the trio) is delivered in a contrasting voice or tessitura. So too with rondos – the main theme can be registered differently from the alternate sections, or vice versa. Songs too might be given a characteristic register to enhance the nature of the text. In this respect it might be mentioned that several sources speak of the main virtue of the new pianos as being that they form 'the ideal accompaniment to the female voice'.
- Third, women in particular found it easier to relate to the neat form and small dimensions of the new piano. While men might delight in overwhelming an audience with the large form and penetrating tone of a harpsichord, playing as many notes as possible with full registration, wives and sisters related more to the square piano's neat form and small size as a more intimate companion with a less strident

⁷ Laboratory identifications indicate vegetable-tanned 'hair sheep'

personality. They also found the portability of Zumpe's piano a great asset. Though the piano might be on public display in the largest room where guests might see it and hear it, if a lady wished to practice in a more private room the servants could easily carry it, and if they set it down gently there might be no disturbance to the tuning. It was also little trouble to transport it from town to country as the social season required.

- Fourth, with Zumpe's almost indestructible action the pianoforte was very rarely out of order. Harpsichords, owing to the use of birds' feathers as plectra, need frequent maintenance. Quills became weak or hard, and had to be replaced if the instrument was to sound well. For women in particular, relief from this chore was a very telling benefit of the pianoforte.
- Fifth, Zumpe's pianos were very reasonably priced. A new harpsichord from Shudi or Kirckman would cost at least £35 for a single manual, while a double with swell might cost £70 or £80. Grand pianos, being prestige items, likewise cost at least £60. But a square piano from Zumpe or Pohlman generally cost about £18 – a very considerable economy. For £25 one could have an elaborately inlaid specimen or have additional refinements.
- Sixth, - one never knows how much weight to give to this – there was the emulation factor. From the very beginning Johann Christian Bach was one of the chief advocates of the English square piano, and he was widely known to be music master to Queen Charlotte. As seventeen-year-old Princess Charlotte from Mecklenburg-Strelitz she had charmed everyone at court with her music making, and it was specially noted at the time that she sang and accompanied herself at the harpsichord, even during her sea voyage to England. When the new pianoforte appeared she had recently presented the nation with a healthy male heir to the throne, ensuring the much longed-for protestant succession, so her popularity could not have been greater. So, when the queen herself played the new pianoforte, the aristocracy and gentry were sure to follow: the instrument needed no further endorsement. Other eminent women who favoured these English square pianos include Marie Antoinette, Queen of France, and Catherine, Empress of Russia, whose favourite musical instrument was a specially commissioned square piano from London combined with a soft-voiced chamber organ. Her gift to Cimarosa of a square piano made by Adam Beyer in London was carried back to Italy and is still preserved in Naples. With such women as these endorsing the instrument its general acceptance among society at large was assured.

Charles Burney, reviewing the transition from harpsichord to pianoforte about thirty years later, writes of his delight in being able to express *chia-oscuro*, light and shade, simply through the touch of the finger. And the repetition he pronounced to be 'equal to any degree of rapidity'. He ought to know. He made a very good living from teaching women pupils, and their daughters. During the London season (when the gentry were in town) he would frequently spend his whole day going from one address to another, charging half-a-guinea for his tuition. It was his chief source of income. Leopold Mozart recommended his son to do likewise, as Wolfgang set out from Mannheim in February 1778. 'Such lady pupils as these will take endless trouble to collect subscriptions for your compositions. The ladies in Paris are omnipotent: they are great amateurs of the clavier, and many of them play extremely well.'⁸ Leopold points out that his son should

⁸ '[...] da dann solche Damen sich noch oben darein alle Mühe geben, für deine Composition Subscribenten zu sammeln. Die Damen machen alles in Paris, - und sind grosse Liebhaberinnen fürs Clavier, und es giebt viele,

on no account give any lessons for free: doesn't his father back home in Salzburg, have to run from house to house for a pittance? The wealthy women of Paris will pay far better. 'They would be your best allies for getting commissions, and you will be able, with their help, to make both fame and money with keyboard pieces, quartets, symphonies, and collections of French songs with clavier such as you lately sent me.'⁹ Needless to say, when he arrived in Paris young Mozart found the fashionable ladies had a great choice of music masters and all were full of enthusiasm for new English square pianos which Johann Christian Bach (and others) were promoting. In fact, in August 1778 young Mozart met Bach in the French capital, where they renewed their former friendship, and then they went off together to St Germaine, to visit Bach's patron, who would very probably have had a square piano supplied from London. This is the context in which Mozart composed his early piano sonatas in Paris.

Charles Burney gives a lively account of his meeting with one of the best of these Parisian lady pianists, the wealthy and vivacious Madame Brillon, who invited him to dinner in June 1770. Her playing had inspired Boccherini to dedicate a set of sonatas to her in 1768, and now two years later Burney found her to be a superb sight reader, easily playing any new music he put in front of her *prima vista*. She had a harpsichord, of course, which we might imagine to be a standard French double manual of the period, but also in the same room, a square piano from London, which J. C. Bach had sent. It would therefore have been by Zumpe & Bunterbart. She loved the stops, so much so that she insisted on playing everything with the dampers off. Burney, not greatly pleased by this endless spice, suggested that she might play one of his own newly-published sonatas with the reverberation put off, but she would have none of it: "C'est sec", she said. Clearly, the novelty on her new piano was a great attraction.¹⁰

Already, in 1770, there were several similar instruments in Paris, and in the following years, and indeed right up to the Revolution, these square pianos on the English pattern proliferated in France. The extent of it can be gauged from the list of instruments confiscated from absent or executed aristocracy in 1791. Forty-four out of a total of forty-seven identifiable pianos was either an English square or a French-made copy in the same style.

Ascendancy of the Square Piano

The earliest dated square piano of the Rhine-area type – with so-called 'Prellmechanik' – was made by Anton Boos in Mainz in 1767.¹¹ Archival research by Christian Ahrens indicates that 'Forte Piano Claviere' (which he interprets as square pianos) were offered for sale in Leipzig area in 1765 (though no specimen survives from this date).¹² And the oldest dated English square piano that survives, by John Zumpe, was made in 1766. So there is a clear convergence of data indicating that small pianofortes in rectangular form

die treflich spielen.' Letter of Leopold Mozart, 16 February 1778, in: Wilhelm A. Bauer and Otto Erich Deutsch (Ed.), *Mozart. Briefe und Aufzeichnungen*, vol. II: 1777-1779, Kassel 1962, p. 284.

⁹ '[...] diese sind deine Leute: und die Composition; da du mit Herausgebung von Claviersachen. – Violinquartetten etc: Sinfonien. und dann auch einer Sammlung guter Franz: Arien mit dem Clavier, wie du mir geschickt: und endlich mit opern, geld und Ruhm machen kannst.' Letter of Leopold Mozart, 16 February 1778, in: Bauer und Deutsch (Ed.), *Mozart. Briefe und Aufzeichnungen* (see footnote 6), p. 284.

¹⁰ Charles Burney, *Music, Men & Manners in France and Italy*, ed. by H. E. Poole, London 19690, p. 20.

¹¹ Germanisches Nationalmuseum MINE 170

¹² Christian Ahrens, *Von der Schwierigkeit eionen Namen zu finden ... Die frühesten deutschen Quellen zum Tafelklavier*, in this volume, pp. 67-79.

began what was to become a very rapid rise to fashionable status, in several regions, within the space of a few years – starting in the mid 1760s. By 1770 some London workshops were producing them to the exclusion of all other types, and soon after 1780 trade in square pianos began to push harpsichord production towards a tailspin decline. One of the advantages of this new instrument, from the musicians' point of view, was that its compact form permitted new owners to accommodate a pianoforte in their homes while keeping an existing harpsichord. Those who opted for a grand pianoforte did not find this accommodation so easy to make. Apart from the great expense of a grand piano, the extravagance of having two large, awkwardly shaped instruments in the same room was not readily countenanced. In London, where there were so many wealthy clients, square pianos out-sold grand pianos by about fifty to one. By 1790 the chief manufacturer of grand pianos was John Broadwood but even from his workshop at least thirty squares were sold for every grand. When one takes account of the production of workshops like those of Adam Beyer and Frederick Schoene (who made nothing but squares) the true prevalence of pianos in the small rectangular format can be seen.

Among Thomas Green's forty-odd clients who had a pianoforte, nine also had a harpsichord. These pianos we may safely assume were almost all squares. So it may have been common practice to select the instrument, either piano or harpsichord, as best suited the character of the music to be performed. Thomas Twining did this in 1774 when his friend Charles Burney sent him a square piano by Pohlman, which Twining placed next to his own harpsichord. Charles Burney himself used both instruments at this time, and when he invited guests to his house in St Martin's Lane in November 1775 it is instructive to see how the instruments were employed. The social intercourse and musical affairs of that day are brilliantly recorded in one of the most memorable passages from Fanny Burney's diaries.¹³

The evening's vocal fare provided by a lady amateur, Mrs. Brudenel, who chose two pretty songs by Rauzzini. This poor lady had bravely stepped in when a professional opera singer had disappointed them, but she was so nervous that she seemed hardly able to open her mouth, and her anxiety caused her to sing often out of tune. These songs were probably accompanied by Hester Burney on a square pianoforte by Zumpe (for we know that there was at least one such instrument in the house). Next her husband Charles Rousseau Burney played an impressive solo on the harpsichord, which was well received. Then for the pinnacle of the evening's entertainment he remained at the harpsichord, Hester took her place at the piano, and together man and wife played a demanding duet sonata by Müthel. This so delighted everyone, and received so much applause, that it was repeated later in the evening. 'The effect of the two instruments together met with the greatest admiration' Fanny writes, and 'Lady Edgecombe, herself a performer of reputation in the lady world, was quite in raptures. She vowed she would practice night and day to be able to perform in such a manner, and said she would rather hear such a duet than twenty operas.'¹⁴ Everyone had some remark to make on the couple who played this piece. Mr. Boone, who sat next to Fanny, remarked, "See what can be done by a man and wife who live in harmony together!" When the Russian guest of honour Prince Orloff was told that they were husband wife he exclaimed: "My word! If they are as much in accord in other things as in their music they will be happy indeed!" He then went up to Hester and made many compliments, expressing his surprise that two people of such well matched talents should be united in life. The Dean of Winchester confided in Fanny: "Your father has been so obliging as to make my two girls attempt something

¹³ Annie Raines Ellis (Ed.), *The Early Diaries of Frances Burney, 1768-78*, vol. 2, London 1889, pp. 102-114

¹⁴ Op. cit., p.112.

of this sort; but if they succeed in a few years they will be none the better for it, because they will be separated: at least they hope so! whereas husband and wife cannot give too much time and trouble to show each other to advantage.”

Ancillary information from Green’s Accounts

The existence of gender differences with regard to various instruments is worthy of further examination. If it is true, as I am proposing, that the progress of the pianoforte was driven principally by the enthusiasm of women for square pianos, usually of the Zumpe type, can we detect any other trends in gender preferences? And how speedily did the piano displace the harpsichord as the instrument of choice? Thomas Green’s accounts offer many further insights in this area.¹⁵

The English ‘Guittar’, a form of cittern with a pear-shaped body and having metal strings, became a fashionable item for lady amateurs during the eighteenth century. So much so that at one point it appeared that the craze for them would eclipse all other instruments. Writing for Abraham Rees’ *Cyclopaedia* around 1803 Charles Burney recalled this fashion, and provides a memorable anecdote concerning Jacob Kirckman, London’s principal harpsichord maker of the period. Alarmed by the Guittar fashion, and fearing that it might undermine sales of harpsichords to fashion-conscious women, Kirckman bought a quantity of these ‘Guittars’ and gave them to ‘milliners’ (i.e. women of very low social status), giving them sufficient tuition to make sure that they could accompany themselves in simple songs. This had the intended result, according to Burney: genteel ladies became alarmed at this association with common women and were soon ashamed of their Guittar-playing and returned to their harpsichords, with Kirckman, ever the shrewd businessman, reaping the profit. The outline of this story is repeated in Boalch, *Makers of the Harpsichord and Clavichord*,¹⁶ where the date ‘about 1770’ is ascribed to these events. Did such a sudden fashion really occur, and is this date correct? Green’s accounts throw some interesting light on this topic. He first mentions such instruments in January 1756 when Lady Sarah Cowper paid him one guinea to mend and string her ‘Citron’. On 14 September he attended to a ‘Citron’ for Lady Mary Mordaunt, but on 14 December he tuned her ‘Guittar’ –presumably the same instrument under another name – and on the same day Lady Frances Mordaunt (her mother-in-law?) paid Green 2 shillings and six pence to tune her Spinnet.

Altogether Green attended to 31 such instruments, but only one of them is said to be for a gentleman. That being true, I compute that the gender bias for the English Guitar is 97 per cent female. So, it was a ladies instrument, just as Burney implies. Observing the dates and frequencies of Green’s encounters with them I detect a sudden fashion for these Guittars emerging in 1756, which is sustained until 1760, and declines rapidly after 1763, after which only a few women persist with the instrument. Burney’s story is consistent with the evidence of Thomas Green both as to gender preference and short-lived fashion status. Tying in very neatly with this is the history of John Zumpe, inventor of the ‘English Piano-forte’. Following his marriage to Elizabeth Beeston in 1760 he left his employment with the harpsichord maker Burkat Shudi to set up his own workshop in

¹⁵ Sheldrick (Ed.), *The Accounts of Thomas Green* (see footnote 5).

¹⁶ Donald Boalch, *Makers of the Harpsichord & Clavichord*, 1440-1840, 3rd edition by Charles Mould (Ed.), Oxford 1995, p. 104.

Princes Street, 'at the sign of the Golden Guittar' (as faithfully documented by Leopold Mozart in his travel notebook for 1764).¹⁷

The only surviving examples of Zumpe's work from the period 1760 to 1765 are instruments of the 'English Guittar' or cittern type, presumably sold to musical ladies of fashion. So we may imagine Zumpe's business enterprise was kick-started by the sale of these fashionable instruments. There is in fact a surviving text to support this further. Laurence Sterne, author of *A Sentimental Journey* etc., wrote to a lady friend in March 1767: 'I have been with Zumps [Zumpe] and your Piano-forte must be tuned from the brass middle string of your Guittar, which is C'.¹⁸ We might deduce therefore that Sterne's lady friend (Eliza Draper) had not only bought one of the first Zumpe pianos but also had previously bought one of his 'Guittars'. A noteworthy feature that connects the two instruments is a special sonority. Today, our best opportunity to hear the metal strung guitar as made by Zumpe is to go to Lisbon for the accompaniment of fado singers where they use an almost identical instrument. The twanging resonance occasioned by plucking (not strumming) metal strings has something in common with the undamped register gained from the use of handstops on the earliest square pianos. Square pianos and English guittars were both reckoned to be well suited to accompany ladies' songs. So, from 1766 onwards John Zumpe's output switched wholly to the 'small Piano forte', which I suggest, like the 'Guittar', is an instrument with a strong gender bias toward females.

Harpsichords versus Pianos

There is a widely held opinion among musicologists and period instrument performers that by 1785 any self-respecting musicians would have given up their harpsichords in favour of the new pianoforte, but this is a very questionable proposition. We know for example that Joseph Haydn's best pupil Madame Genzinger was still playing her harpsichord in 1788. (She did not own a piano). We cannot dismiss this as an aberration caused by conservative tastes at Esterhazy. The same thing was happening in prosperous areas near London. To gauge the situation within Green's territory, I subjected his records to a further examination to see who was playing the harpsichord, and to see if any diminution of harpsichord playing could be discerned in the period up to 1786 (when Green's records cease). My first finding is that there is a clear increase in the number of women harpsichord players as the decades progress. Analysing the period 1742-1760 I compute that more females play than males, but the difference is not great: men represent 40 per cent of players, women 60 per cent. However, Green's records show the proportion of women rises to 75 per cent between 1760 and 1786. What happens when pianofortes appear in local houses is that contemporaneously harpsichord playing appears to be also increasing. Basically, more women are playing the harpsichord than ever before. The received wisdom, that after 1780 the pianoforte was wholly dominant, and that only very conservative musicians played the harpsichord is completely confounded. Taking the years 1783, 84 and 85 I find that he notes down 47 tunings of harpsichords and spinets, but only 23 for the piano. Now one could argue that Green, being by then a conservative and old-fashioned musician (aged well over 60) had little sympathy with the new instrument and was therefore less likely to be asked to tune one, but what cannot be contradicted is that among a relatively affluent society, only twenty

¹⁷ Arthur Schurig (Ed.), *Leopold Mozart Reise-Aufzeichnungen, 1763-1771*, Dresden 1920.

¹⁸ Laurence Sterne, *Letters of Yorrick to Eliza* (op. posth.), London 1773, from letter dated April 1767.

miles from the epicentre of the pianoforte revolution, there is no sign that people are giving up their harpsichords. They are apparently keeping them in good order and using them often. In 1786, the very last year of Green's activity (his records end at 21st June that year) he tuned 13 harpsichords and 5 pianofortes. More is the pity that Green was not active a few years longer. It would have been interesting to see whether this was truly the turning point.

The Significance of Music-making for Women

For middle-class women, or ladies with any social status, employment (in the modern sense, for monetary reward) was unthinkable. Only women from the lower classes took paid employment. Servants could attend to all menial tasks – cooking and serving meals, and dealing with tradesmen. A lady's task was at most to see that these tasks had been properly carried out. For recreation a lady who was not encumbered with children might draw and paint, she might even write, although the prospects for publication would be very restricted. Very often women who wrote did so furtively. Fanny Burney hid her 'scribbling' even from her father, who was himself an author. He only discovered the extent and quality of her writing after her first novel had been published, anonymously. Jane Austen would write on single leaves, which she could push under the tablecloth if anyone entered the room. Her works were likewise printed without the author's name. None of these activities gave women any opportunity to exhibit themselves or their creative efforts in any meaningful way. Amateur play-acting could only be indulged in the home, with close friends or family members, but this was discouraged in most homes, as it might excite inappropriate emotions, which would be better suppressed. Drawings might be admired, a tapestry too. But music was in reality the only activity in which a woman could command the whole attention of mixed company. While she sang or sat at the keyboard she was (hopefully) the sole focus of everyone's attention.

However, performing music in public was out of the question for any woman who had a social standing to protect. Even Elizabeth Linley, the famous 'nightingale of Bath', who could command enormous fees for singing oratorios, was prohibited from singing in public as soon as she married. Sheridan, her husband, absolutely forbade it, even though he was formerly an actor himself! Marianne Mozart (Nannerl) was an excellent musician even at ten years old, yet she would never have been expected to earn money by playing once she reached adult status. And, of course, there was no thought that she should ever emulate her brother's exploits as a composer. So, for personal fulfillment in a social sphere, playing the harpsichord or pianoforte was an exceptional opportunity for women. And in this they were encouraged warmly in their younger days. Girls between the ages of fifteen and twenty could attract admirers, and it was expected that they would in this way enhance their prospects of an advantageous marriage – as Jane Austen's novels tastefully suggest.

Girls' education was often very scant. At best they shared their brother's lessons with a tutor at home, but when the boy went away to school, as was usually the case at about ten or eleven years of age, such lessons might not continue. Sending a daughter away to a boarding school was becoming more common around 1780, but usually only for a year or so. Two of Charles Burney's daughters were given the exceptional benefit of a year at a school in France. Jane Austen and her sister spent only one year at school, and it was while there that Jane had her chance to learn the piano. But within a year she became gravely ill and was rushed home, never to return. At such schools there would be a very limited curriculum: elementary geography, scripture, and needlework and – increasingly from 1780 onwards – singing and pianoforte. Mostly the music teachers were male; often

a local organist. Thomas Green gave such lessons at several schools in his neighbourhood.

After 1800 it became much more common for such tuition to be given by women: they were the second generation of pianists, so to speak, and from the beginning of the nineteenth century girls who had acquired a skill in music, but who were unprovided for later in life, could turn this to account. For a respectable woman who was thrown upon her own resources there might be only two options: to live as a dependent spinster or widow in the home of a relative, or to support herself by teaching, while living very frugally. Music skills were invaluable in such a situation. For the brave and thrifty woman teaching music and/or drawing made it possible to live independently without sinking to the social status of tradesmen, such as shopkeepers. Some can be detected placing newspaper advertisements in the early part of the nineteenth century, especially in towns like Bath or Cheltenham where wealthy clients brought their families for the season. But as material prosperity spread through society embracing an ever-increasing segment of the population, many families wanted their daughters to acquire a veneer of gentility. Playing the pianoforte was an easily paraded mark of such status, and since second-hand or used instruments made the acquisition of a piano easier, any town or city might provide work for music teachers, and this provided an opportunity for women to take over what had previously been a male prerogative. One such woman was Josabeth Sjöberg (18912=18982) living in Oslo, who has left a very touching and useful record of her life spent in this way. In a sketch book of water colours¹⁹ she recorded the interior of every room that she rented over many years (she could only afford one room). In them we can see her instrument²⁰ (actually a rather old-fashioned one by 1840, with square-tapering legs) and her gut-strung guitar. Her possessions were very few, but the detailed, primitive-style pictures now make an invaluable resource for those researching interior decoration in the period through which she lived. Simple though her life was, her small talent enabled her to live alone, maintaining herself almost until her seventieth year, when she at last moved into a home for elderly women.

Conclusions

1. During the period 1765 to 1795 about 80% of pianoforte players (or more) were female. Social conventions prevented most of these women from appearing as professional musicians. Nevertheless, their influence was very considerable: it was they who were the principal consumers of goods and services and, as transmitters of musical culture, women were the indispensable agency through which European art music was mediated to society at large.
2. The great majority of these women, from whatever country, showed a preference for square pianos, of which the so-called 'English Pianoforte' was overwhelmingly the most prestigious and dominant type. The special tonal qualities of such instruments in the period 1766 to 1800 are quite different from the Viennese fortepiano of the modern revival. In addition, some of the special registrations (mutation stops) are unique to this type of instrument, and may have been contributed significantly to its popularity.

¹⁹ Peter Thornton, *Authentic Décor, Domestic Interiors 1620-1920*, London 1984, p. 277.

²⁰ Note: Was this a square piano? A Swedish colleague, Mats Krouthén, points out that since we cannot actually see a pedal under this instrument it could be a five-a-half octave clavichord, such as were still being made in Sweden up to 1820. Be that as it may, we take nothing from Josabeth Sjöberg's story.

3. For women, music making, and particularly playing the pianoforte, offered a unique opportunity for individual expression. It was perhaps the only situation in which a woman could command the whole attention of a mixed company and take credit unashamedly for her own abilities.
4. In the early piano period (up to 1790) most teachers of the pianoforte were male. Men like J. C. Bach, Schroeter, Clememti, and Kozeluch earned a considerable proportion of their income from giving such lessons. Charles Burney, who is remembered chiefly as a great music historian and author, rarely appeared as a professional musician: his principal income comprised the fees he got from a long list of female pupils to whom he gave tuition at home. However, soon after 1800 teaching such skills was undertaken by women, particularly in schools where girls received an otherwise rudimentary education. By 1830 some women who were forced by circumstances to provide for themselves made a sustainable living by teaching singing and pianoforte: for them the pianoforte became a lifeline to independence.